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Gaming system with feature game having collectable components for prizes

Abstract

An electronic gaming device comprising a display that displays a plurality of symbols in a plurality of symbol positions, a game controller that determines if the plurality of symbols include a trigger symbol, in response to determining that the plurality of symbols include the trigger symbol, controls the display to display the trigger symbol being transformed into a prize component symbol, incrementally animates a filling of a prize component of a first prize with the prize component symbol, and awards the first prize when a plurality of first prize components have been completely filled.

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Background/Summary

RELATED APPLICATIONS

(1) The present application claims priority to U.S. patent application Ser. No. 17/129,427, filed Dec. 21, 2020, and entitled “Gaming System with Feature Game Having Collectable Components for Prizes,” which claims priority to U.S. patent application Ser. No. 16/779,540, filed Jan. 31, 2020, issued on Dec. 22, 2020, as U.S. Pat. No. 10,872,502, and entitled “Gaming System with Feature Game Having Collectable Components for Prizes,” which claims priority to Australian Patent Application No. 2019901012, filed Mar. 26, 2019, and also Australian Patent Application No. 2019232939, filed Sep. 20, 2019, which are hereby incorporated by reference in their entireties.

BACKGROUND

(2) Electronic gaming machines (“EGMs”) or gaming devices provide a variety of wagering games such as slot games, video poker games, video blackjack games, roulette games, video bingo games, keno games and other types of games that are frequently offered at casinos and other locations. Play on EGMs typically involves a player establishing a credit balance by inputting money, or another form of monetary credit, and placing a monetary wager (from the credit balance) on one or more outcomes of an instance (or single play) of a primary or base game. In many games, a player may qualify for secondary games or bonus rounds by attaining a certain winning combination or triggering event in the base game. Secondary games provide an opportunity to win additional game instances, credits, awards, jackpots, progressives, etc. Awards from any winning outcomes are typically added back to the credit balance and can be provided to the player upon completion of a gaming session or when the player wants to “cash out.”

(3) “Slot” type games are often displayed to the player in the form of various symbols arrayed in a row-by-column grid or matrix. Specific matching combinations of symbols along predetermined paths (or paylines) through the matrix indicate the outcome of the game. The display typically highlights winning combinations/outcomes for ready identification by the player. Matching combinations and their corresponding awards are usually shown in a “pay-table” which is available to the player for reference. Often, the player may vary his/her wager to include differing numbers of paylines and/or the amount bet on each line. By varying the wager, the player may sometimes alter the frequency or number of winning combinations, frequency or number of secondary games, and/or the amount awarded.

(4) Typical games use a random number generator (RNG) to randomly determine the outcome of each game. The game is designed to return a certain percentage of the amount wagered back to the player (RTP=return to player) over the course of many plays or instances of the game. The RTP and randomness of the RNG are critical to ensuring the fairness of the games and are therefore highly regulated. Upon initiation of play, the RNG randomly determines a game outcome and symbols are then selected which correspond to that outcome. Notably, some games may include an element of skill on the part of the player and are therefore not entirely random.

SUMMARY

(5) Certain embodiments provide a gaming device, a method of operating a gaming device and a system where a composite feature game can be retriggered during a series of free games of a spinning reel game. If a feature is retriggered during the free games, the feature is collected. At the end of the free games, the processor examines the identity of the collected features. If two or more features are collected, the processor conducts a composite feature that has the characteristics of the individual feature games.

(6) In an embodiment, a gaming device comprises a display, a processor, and a memory storing a) symbol data defining a plurality of reel strips, the reel strips comprising symbols including at least a first trigger symbol associated with a first feature game, a second trigger symbol associated with a second feature game and a plurality of non-trigger symbols, the symbols arranged on the reel strips so that one or both of the first and second trigger symbols can be selected at the same time, and (b) instructions. When the instructions are executed by the processor, they cause the processor to a) initiate a series of free games in response to the occurrence of a designated trigger condition. In each free game, the instructions cause the processor to (i) select symbols from the reel strips for display in a plurality of columns of symbol positions, wherein each column of symbol positions corresponds to a reel strip of the plurality of reel strips, (ii) display the selected symbols on the display in the plurality of columns of symbol positions, (iii) determine based at least in part on whether the selected symbols include one or both of the first and second trigger symbols, whether a trigger condition is met in respect of one or both of the first feature game and the second feature game, and (iii) upon a trigger condition being met in respect of one or both of the first and second trigger symbols, set the respective feature game as triggered. Upon both the first and second feature games being set as triggered at the conclusion of the free games, the instructions cause the processor to conduct a first composite feature game incorporating at least one characteristic of each of the first and second feature games.

(7) Another embodiment, provides a method of operating a gaming device comprising a display and a memory storing symbol data defining a plurality of reel strips, the reel strips comprising symbols including at least a first trigger symbol associated with a first feature game, a second trigger symbol associated with a second feature game and a plurality of non-trigger symbols, the symbols arranged on the reel strips so that one or both of the first and second trigger symbols can be selected at the same time. The method comprises initiating a series of free games in response to the occurrence of a designated trigger condition. In each free game, the method comprises (i) selecting symbols from the reel strips for display in a plurality of columns of symbol positions, wherein each column of symbol positions corresponds to a reel strip of the plurality of reel strips, (ii) displaying the selected symbols on the display in the plurality of columns of symbol positions, (iii) determining based at least in part on whether the selected symbols include one or both of the first and second trigger symbols, whether a trigger condition is met in respect of one or both of the first feature game and the second feature game, and (iii) upon a trigger condition being met in respect of one or both of the first and second trigger symbols, setting the respective feature game as triggered. Upon both the first and second feature games being set as triggered at the conclusion of the free games, the method comprises conducting a first composite feature game incorporating at least one characteristic of each of the first and second feature games.

(8) Another embodiment provides a system comprising one or more processors, and at least one memory storing (a) symbol data defining a plurality of reel strips, the reel strips comprising symbols including at least a first trigger symbol associated with a first feature game, a second trigger symbol associated with a second feature game and a plurality of non-trigger symbols, the symbols arranged on the reel strips so that one or both of the first and second trigger symbols can be selected at the same time, and (b) instructions. When the instructions are executed by the one or more processors, they cause the one or more processors to a) initiate a series of free games in response to the occurrence of a designated trigger condition. In each free game, the instructions cause the one or more processors to (i) select symbols from the reel strips for display in a plurality of columns of symbol positions, wherein each column of symbol positions corresponds to a reel strip of the plurality of reel strips, (ii) display the selected symbols on a display in the plurality of columns of symbol positions, (iii) determine based at least in part on whether the selected symbols include one or both of the first and second trigger symbols, whether a trigger condition is met in respect of one or both of the first feature game and the second feature game, and (iii) upon a trigger condition being met in respect of one or both of the first and second trigger symbols, set the

respective feature game as triggered. Upon both the first and second feature games being set as triggered at the conclusion of the free games, the instructions cause the one or more processors to conduct a first composite feature game incorporating at least one characteristic of each of the first and second feature games.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

- (1) FIG. 1 is an exemplary diagram showing several EGMs networked with various gaming related servers.
- (2) FIG. 2 is a block diagram showing various functional elements of an exemplary EGM.
- (3) FIG. 3 illustrates an example reel strip layout.
- (4) FIG. 4 is a flow chart of a symbol selection method.
- (5) FIG. 5 is a flow chart of an embodiment.
- (6) FIGS. 6, 7, 8, and 9 are example screen displays.
- (7) FIG. 10 is a flow chart of an embodiment.
- (8) FIG. 11 illustrates another example reel strip layout.
- (9) FIGS. 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, and 25 are example screen displays.
- (10) FIG. 26 is a flow chart of an embodiment.
- (11) FIG. 27 illustrates another example reel strip layout.
- (12) FIGS. 28, 29, 30, 31, 32, 33 and 34 are example screen displays.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

(13) Embodiments of the present disclosure represent a technical improvement in the art of electronic gaming machines, systems, and operating for such electronic gaming machines or systems. For example, at least some embodiments of the present disclosure provide additional functionality in an electronic gaming machine by employing a display that provides a visual transformation of game characteristics. In such embodiments, a plurality of symbols are randomly selected for animated display at a plurality of symbol positions during a series of free games. When the plurality of symbols selected include one or both of a first trigger symbol and a second trigger symbol, the gaming machine randomly collects a respective trigger based on the one or both of the first trigger symbol and the second trigger symbol. When both of the first trigger symbol and the second trigger symbol have been collected, the gaming machine conducts a composite game incorporating one characteristic of the first feature game and one characteristic of the second feature game.

(14) Embodiments of the present disclosure represent another technical improvement in the art of electronic gaming machines, systems, and operating for such electronic gaming machines or systems. For example, at least some embodiments of the present disclosure provide additional functionality in an electronic gaming machine by employing a display that provides a visual transformation of game characteristics. In such embodiments, a plurality of symbols are randomly selected for animated display at a plurality of symbol positions. When the plurality of symbols selected include a first trigger symbol, the gaming machine randomly transforms the first trigger symbol into a prize component symbol. The gaming machine animates a filling of one of a plurality of prize components of a prize. When the plurality of prize components of the prize is complete, the gaming machine presents the prize.

(15) Embodiments of the present disclosure represent another technical improvement in the art of electronic gaming machines, systems, and operating for such electronic gaming machines or systems. For example, at least some embodiments of the present disclosure provide additional functionality in an electronic gaming machine by employing a display that provides a visual transformation of game characteristics. In such embodiments, a plurality of symbols are randomly

selected for animated display at a plurality of symbol positions. When the plurality of symbols selected include a first trigger symbol but not a second trigger symbol, the gaming machine randomly determines whether to conduct a first feature game based on one or more of a plurality of random numbers. When the plurality of symbols selected include the first trigger symbol and a second trigger symbol, the gaming machine randomly determines whether to conduct a third feature game selected among the first feature game, a second feature game, and a composite game incorporating at least one characteristic of each of the first feature game and the second feature game.

(16) Further, the visual modification of game characteristics also provides an improved game machine display such that the player may only need to focus on symbols being displayed, visually collected, and visually moved to one or more prizes, without being overly burdened by complicated calculations. Further, embodiments of the present disclosure also provide multiple visual symbol collections to illustrate certain game characteristic combinations that are not conventional, as those that utilize memory to store symbol data for multiple symbol sets, such that one or more of these multiple sets are used to configure composite game characteristics to be selected. Thus, embodiments of the present disclosure are not merely new game rules or simply new display patterns, but provide technologic improvements to game display in the art of electronic gaming machines and software for such electronic gaming machines. Moreover, the above example is not intended to be limiting, but merely exemplary of technologic improvements provided by some embodiments of the present disclosure. Technological improvements of other embodiments are readily apparent to those of ordinary skill in the art in light of the present disclosure.

(17) FIG. 1 illustrates several different models of EGMs which may be networked to various gaming related servers. The present disclosure can be configured to work as a system **100** in a gaming environment including one or more server computers **102** (e.g., slot servers of a casino) that are in communication, via a communications network, with one or more gaming devices **104A-104X** (EGMs, slots, video poker, bingo machines, etc.). The gaming devices **104A-104X** may alternatively be portable and/or remote gaming devices such as, but not limited to, a smart phone, a tablet, a laptop, or a game console.

(18) Communication between the gaming devices **104A-104X** and the server computers **102**, and among the gaming devices **104A-104X**, may be direct or indirect, such as over the Internet through a web site maintained by a computer on a remote server or over an online data network including commercial online service providers, Internet service providers, private networks, and the like. In other embodiments, the gaming devices **104A-104X** may communicate with one another and/or the server computers **102** over RF, cable TV, satellite links and the like.

(19) In some embodiments, server computers **102** may not be necessary and/or preferred. For example, the present disclosure may, in one or more embodiments, be practiced on a standalone gaming device such as gaming device **104A**, gaming device **104B** or any of the other gaming devices **104C-104X**. However, it is typical to find multiple EGMs connected to networks implemented with one or more of the different server computers **102** described herein.

(20) The server computers **102** may include a central determination gaming system server **106**, a ticket-in-ticket-out (TITO) system server **108**, a player tracking system server **110**, a progressive system server **112**, and/or a casino management system server **114**. Gaming devices **104A-104X** may include features to enable operation of any or all servers for use by the player and/or operator (e.g., the casino, resort, gaming establishment, tavern, pub, etc.). For example, game outcomes may be generated on a central determination gaming system server **106** and then transmitted over the network to any of a group of remote terminals or remote gaming devices **104A-104X** that utilize the game outcomes and display the results to the players.

(21) Gaming device **104A** is often of a cabinet construction which may be aligned in rows or banks of similar devices for placement and operation on a casino floor. The gaming device **104A** often includes a main cabinet **116** which provides access to the interior of the cabinet. Gaming device

104A typically includes a button area or button deck **120** accessible by a player that is configured with input switches or buttons **122**, an access channel for a bill validator **124**, and/or an access channel for a ticket-out printer **126**.

(22) In FIG. **1**, gaming device **104A** is shown as a Relm XL™ model gaming device manufactured by Aristocrat® Technologies, Inc. As shown, gaming device **104A** is a reel machine having a gaming display area **118** comprising a number (typically 3 or 5) of mechanical reels **130** with various symbols displayed on them. The reels **130** are independently spun and stopped to show a set of symbols within the gaming display area **118** which may be used to determine an outcome to the game. In embodiments where the reels are mechanical, mechanisms can be employed to implement greater functionality. For example, the boundaries of the gaming display area boundaries of the gaming display area **118** may be defined by one or more mechanical shutters controllable by a processor. The mechanical shutters may be controlled to open and close, to correspondingly reveal and conceal more or fewer symbol positions from the mechanical reels **130**. For example, a top boundary of the gaming display area **118** may be raised by moving a corresponding mechanical shutter upwards to reveal an additional row of symbol positions on stopped mechanical reels. Further, a transparent or translucent display panel may be overlaid on the gaming display area **118** and controlled to override or supplement what is displayed on one or more of the mechanical reel(s).

(23) In many configurations, the gaming machine **104A** may have a main display **128** (e.g., video display monitor) mounted to, or above, the gaming display area **118**. The main display **128** can be a high-resolution LCD, plasma, LED, or OLED panel which may be flat or curved as shown, a cathode ray tube, or other conventional electronically controlled video monitor.

(24) In some embodiments, the bill validator **124** may also function as a “ticket-in” reader that allows the player to use a casino issued credit ticket to load credits onto the gaming device **104A** (e.g., in a cashless ticket (“TITO”) system). In such cashless embodiments, the gaming device **104A** may also include a “ticket-out” printer **126** for outputting a credit ticket when a “cash out” button is pressed. Cashless TITO systems are well known in the art and are used to generate and track unique bar-codes or other indicators printed on tickets to allow players to avoid the use of bills and coins by loading credits using a ticket reader and cashing out credits using a ticket-out printer **126** on the gaming device **104A**. In some embodiments a ticket reader can be used which is only capable of reading tickets. In some embodiments, a different form of token can be used to store a cash value, such as a magnetic stripe card.

(25) In some embodiments, a player tracking card reader **144**, a transceiver for wireless communication with a player's smartphone, a keypad **146**, and/or an illuminated display **148** for reading, receiving, entering, and/or displaying player tracking information is provided in gaming device **104A** (e.g., an EGM). In such embodiments, a game controller within the gaming device **104A** can communicate with the player tracking system server **110** to send and receive player tracking information.

(26) Gaming device **104A** may also include a bonus topper wheel **134**. When bonus play is triggered (e.g., by a player achieving a particular outcome or set of outcomes in the primary game), bonus topper wheel **134** is operative to spin and stop with indicator arrow **136** indicating the outcome of the bonus game. Bonus topper wheel **134** is typically used to play a bonus game, but it could also be incorporated into play of the base or primary game.

(27) A candle **138** may be mounted on the top of gaming device **104A** and may be activated by a player (e.g., using a switch or one of buttons **122**) to indicate to operations staff that gaming device **104A** has experienced a malfunction or the player requires service. The candle **138** is also often used to indicate a jackpot has been won and to alert staff that a hand payout of an award may be needed.

(28) There may also be one or more information panels **152** which may be a backlit, silkscreened glass panel with lettering to indicate general game information including, for example, a game

denomination (e.g., \$0.25 or \$1), pay lines, pay tables, and/or various game related graphics. In some embodiments, the information panel(s) **152** may be implemented as an additional video display.

(29) Gaming devices **104A** have traditionally also included a handle **132** typically mounted to the side of main cabinet **116** which may be used to initiate game play.

(30) Many or all the above described components can be controlled by circuitry (e.g., a gaming controller) housed inside the main cabinet **116** of the gaming device **104A**, the details of which are shown in FIG. 2.

(31) Note that not all gaming devices suitable for implementing embodiments of the present disclosure necessarily include top wheels, top boxes, information panels, cashless ticket systems, and/or player tracking systems. Further, some suitable gaming devices have only a single game display that includes only a mechanical set of reels and/or a video display, while others are designed for bar counters or table tops and have displays that face upwards.

(32) An alternative example gaming device **104B** illustrated in FIG. 1 is the Arc™ model gaming device manufactured by Aristocrat® Technologies, Inc. Note that where possible, reference numerals identifying similar features of the gaming device **104A** embodiment are also identified in the gaming device **104B** embodiment using the same reference numbers. Gaming device **104B** does not include physical reels and instead shows game play functions on main display **128**. An optional topper screen **140** may be used as a secondary game display for bonus play, to show game features or attraction activities while a game is not in play, or any other information or media desired by the game designer or operator. In some embodiments, topper screen **140** may also or alternatively be used to display progressive jackpot prizes available to a player during play of gaming device **104B**.

(33) Example gaming device **104B** includes a main cabinet **116** including a main door which opens to provide access to the interior of the gaming device **104B**. The main or service door is typically used by service personnel to refill the ticket-out printer **126** and collect bills and tickets inserted into the bill validator **124**. The door may also be accessed to reset the machine, verify and/or upgrade the software, and for general maintenance operations.

(34) Another example gaming device **104C** shown is the Helix™ model gaming device manufactured by Aristocrat® Technologies, Inc. Gaming device **104C** includes a main display **128A** that is in a landscape orientation. Although not illustrated by the front view provided, the landscape display **128A** may have a curvature radius from top to bottom, or alternatively from side to side. In some embodiments, display **128A** is a flat panel display. Main display **128A** is typically used for primary game play while secondary display **128B** is typically used for bonus game play, to show game features or attraction activities while the game is not in play or any other information or media desired by the game designer or operator.

(35) Many different types of games, including mechanical slot games, video slot games, video poker, video black jack, video pachinko, keno, bingo, and lottery, may be provided with or implemented within the depicted gaming devices **104A-104C** and other similar gaming devices. Each gaming device may also be operable to provide many different games. Games may be differentiated according to themes, sounds, graphics, type of game (e.g., slot game vs. card game vs. game with aspects of skill), denomination, number of paylines, maximum jackpot, progressive or non-progressive, bonus games, and may be deployed for operation in Class 2 or Class 3, etc.

(36) FIG. 2 is a block diagram depicting exemplary internal electronic components of a gaming device **200** connected to various external systems. All or parts of the example gaming device **200** shown could be used to implement any one of the example gaming devices **104A-X** depicted in FIG. 1. The games available for play on the gaming device **200** are controlled by a game controller **202** that includes one or more processors **204** and a game that may be stored as game software or a program **206** in a memory **208** coupled to the processor **204**. The memory **208** may include one or more mass storage devices or media that are housed within gaming device **200**. Within the mass

storage devices and/or memory **208**, one or more databases **210** may be provided for use by the program **206**. A random number generator (RNG) **212** that can be implemented in hardware and/or software is typically used to generate random numbers that are used in the operation of game play to ensure that game play outcomes are random and meet regulations for a game of chance. In some embodiments, the RNG **212** is a pseudo-random number generator.

(37) Alternatively, a game instance (i.e. a play or round of the game) may be generated on a remote gaming device such as a central determination gaming system server **106** (not shown in FIG. **2** but see FIG. **1**). The game instance is communicated to gaming device **200** via the network **214** and then displayed on gaming device **200**. Gaming device **200** may execute game software, such as but not limited to video streaming software that allows the game to be displayed on gaming device **200**. When a game is stored on gaming device **200**, it may be loaded from a memory **208** (e.g., from a read only memory (ROM)) or from the central determination gaming system server **106** to memory **208**. The memory **208** may include RAM, ROM or another form of storage media that stores instructions for execution by the processor **204**.

(38) The gaming device **200** may include a topper display **216** or another form of a top box (e.g., a topper wheel, a topper screen, etc.) which sits above main cabinet **218**. The gaming cabinet **218** or topper display **216** may also house a number of other components which may be used to add features to a game being played on gaming device **200**, including speakers **220**, a ticket printer **222** which prints barcoded tickets or other media or mechanisms for storing or indicating a player's credit value, a ticket reader **224** which reads bar-coded tickets or other media or mechanisms for storing or indicating a player's credit value, and a player tracking interface **232**. The player tracking interface **232** may include a keypad **226** for entering information, a player tracking display **228** for displaying information (e.g., an illuminated or video display), a card reader **230** for receiving data and/or communicating information to and from media or a device such as a smart phone enabling player tracking. Ticket printer **222** may be used to print tickets for a TITO system server **108**. The gaming device **200** may further include a bill validator **234**, buttons **236** for player input, cabinet security sensors **238** to detect unauthorized opening of the cabinet **218**, a primary game display **240**, and a secondary game display **242**, each coupled to and operable under the control of game controller **202**.

(39) Gaming device **200** may be connected over network **214** to player tracking system server **110**. Player tracking system server **110** may be, for example, an OASIS® system manufactured by Aristocrat® Technologies, Inc. Player tracking system server **110** is used to track play (e.g. amount wagered, games played, time of play and/or other quantitative or qualitative measures) for individual players so that an operator may reward players in a loyalty program. The player may use the player tracking interface **232** to access his/her account information, activate free play, and/or request various information. Player tracking or loyalty programs seek to reward players for their play and help build brand loyalty to the gaming establishment. The rewards typically correspond to the player's level of patronage (e.g., to the player's playing frequency and/or total amount of game plays at a given casino). Player tracking rewards may be complimentary and/or discounted meals, lodging, entertainment and/or additional play. Player tracking information may be combined with other information that is now readily obtainable by a casino management system.

(40) Gaming devices, such as gaming devices **104A-104X**, **200**, are highly regulated to ensure fairness and, in many cases, gaming devices **104A-104X**, **200** are operable to award monetary awards (e.g., typically dispensed in the form of a redeemable voucher). Therefore, to satisfy security and regulatory requirements in a gaming environment, hardware and software architectures are implemented in gaming devices **104A-104X**, **200** that differ significantly from those of general-purpose computers. Adapting general purpose computers to function as gaming devices **200** is not simple or straightforward because of: 1) the regulatory requirements for gaming devices **200**, 2) the harsh environment in which gaming devices **200** operate, 3) security requirements, 4) fault tolerance requirements, and 5) the requirement for additional special purpose componentry

enabling functionality of an EGM. These differences require substantial engineering effort with respect to game design implementation, hardware components and software.

(41) One regulatory requirement for games running on gaming device **200** generally involves complying with a certain level of randomness (e.g., that outcomes will be statistically independent, uniformly distributed over their range, unpredictable and pass statistical tests such as chi-square test, equi-distribution test, gap test, runs test, serial correlation test, etc.). Typically, gaming jurisdictions mandate that gaming devices **200** satisfy a minimum level of randomness without specifying how a gaming device **200** should achieve this level of randomness. To comply, FIG. 2 illustrates that gaming device **200** includes an RNG **212** that utilizes hardware and/or software to generate RNG outcomes that lack any pattern. The RNG **212** can be integrated into the game controller **202** or processor **204**. The RNG operations are often specialized and non-generic in order to comply with regulatory and gaming requirements. For example, in a reel game, program **206** can initiate multiple RNG calls to RNG **212** to generate RNG outcomes, where each RNG call and RNG outcome corresponds to an outcome for a reel. (Gaming regulations may require that each reel outcome be independent of each other reel outcome, such that no reel outcome depends on any other reel outcome.) In another example, gaming device **200** can be a Class II gaming device where RNG **212** generates RNG outcomes for creating Bingo cards. In one or more embodiments, RNG **212** could be one of a set of RNGs operating on gaming device **200**. More generally, an output of the RNG **212** can be the basis on which game outcomes are determined by the game controller **202**. Game developers could vary the degree of true randomness for each RNG (e.g., pseudorandom) and utilize specific RNGs depending on game requirements. The output of the RNG **212** can include a random number or pseudorandom number (either is generally referred to as a “random number”).

(42) Another regulatory requirement for running games on gaming device **200** includes ensuring a certain level of RTP. Similar to the randomness requirement discussed above, numerous gaming jurisdictions also mandate that gaming device **200** provides a minimum level of RTP (e.g., RTP of at least 75%).

(43) A game can use one or more weighted tables as part of a technical solution that satisfies regulatory requirements for randomness and RTP. In particular, a weighted table can integrate game features (e.g., trigger events for special modes or bonus games; newly introduced game elements such as extra reels, new symbols, or new cards; stop positions for dynamic game elements such as spinning reels, spinning wheels, or shifting reels; or card selections from a deck) with random numbers generated by one or more RNGs, so as to achieve a given level of volatility for a target level of RTP. (In general, volatility refers to the frequency or probability of an event such as a special mode, payout, etc. For example, for a target level of RTP, a higher-volatility game may have a lower payout most of the time with an occasional bonus having a very high payout, while a lower-volatility game has a steadier payout with more frequent bonuses of smaller amounts.) Configuring a weighted table can involve engineering decisions with respect to how RNG outcomes are mapped to game outcomes for a given game feature, while still satisfying regulatory requirements for RTP. Configuring a weighted table can also involve engineering decisions about whether different game features are combined in a given entry of the weighted table or split between different entries (for the respective game features), while still satisfying regulatory requirements for RTP and allowing for varying levels of game volatility.

(44) To meet a designated RTP, a game developer can utilize one or more weighted tables (e.g., weighted tables) to translate the RNG outcome to a symbol element, stop position on a reel strip layout, and/or randomly chosen aspect of a game feature. As an example, the weighted tables can regulate a prize payout amount for each RNG outcome and how often the gaming device **200** pays out the prize payout amounts. The gaming device **200** could utilize one weighted table to map the RNG outcome to a game outcome displayed to a player and a second weighted table as a pay table for determining the prize payout amount for each game outcome. The mapping between the RNG

outcome to the game outcome controls the frequency in hitting certain prize payout amounts.

(45) When a player wishes to play the gaming device **200**, he/she can insert cash or a ticket voucher through a coin acceptor (not shown) or bill validator **234** to establish a credit balance on the game machine. The credit balance is used by the player to place wagers on instances of the game and to receive credit awards based on the outcome of winning instances. The credit balance is decreased by the amount of each wager and increased upon a win. The player can add additional credits to the balance at any time. The player may also optionally insert a loyalty club card into the card reader **230**. During the game, the player views the game outcome on the game displays **240**, **242**. Other game and prize information may also be displayed.

(46) For each game instance, a player may make selections, which may affect play of the game. For example, the player may vary the total amount wagered by selecting the amount bet per line and the number of lines played. In many games, the player is asked to initiate or select options during course of game play (such as spinning a wheel to begin a bonus round or select various items during a feature game). The player may make these selections using the player-input buttons **236**, the primary game display **240** which may be a touch screen, or using some other input device which enables a player to input information into the gaming device **200**. In some embodiments, a player's selection may apply across a plurality of game instances. For example, if the player is awarded additional game instances in the form of free games, the player's prior selection of the amount bet per line and the number of lines played may apply to the free games. The selections available to a player will vary depending on the embodiment. For example, in some embodiments a number of pay lines may be fixed. In other embodiments, the available selections may include different numbers of ways to win instead of different numbers of pay lines.

(47) During certain game events, the gaming device **200** may display visual and auditory effects that can be perceived by the player. These effects add to the excitement of a game, which makes a player more likely to enjoy the playing experience. Auditory effects include various sounds that are projected by the speakers **220**. Visual effects include flashing lights, strobing lights or other patterns displayed from lights on the gaming device **200** or from lights behind the information panel **152** (FIG. 1).

(48) When the player is done, he/she cashes out the credit balance (typically by pressing a cash out button to receive a ticket from the ticket printer **222**). The ticket may be "cashed-in" for money or inserted into another machine to establish a credit balance for play.

(49) FIG. 3 illustrates an example of a set **300** of five reel strips **321**, **322**, **323**, **324**, **325**. In the example, each reel strip has fifteen reel strip positions **301-315**. Each reel strip position of each reel has a symbol. For example, a "WILD" symbol **331** occupies the sixth reel strip position **306** of the fourth reel **324**. The reel strips **321-325** are configured so that more than one trigger symbol can be selected at once. In this example, the reel strips include three different trigger symbols ("SCAT 1", "SCAT 2", and "SCAT 3"). The trigger symbols are located across the reel strips such that they can be selected concurrently, in particular by being selected from different reels. One possible selectable combination of all three trigger symbols is the selection of SCAT 3 symbol **343** from first reel **321**, SCAT 1 symbol **344** from third reel **323**, and SCAT 2 symbol from fifth reel **325**. ("SCAT" is an abbreviation for "scatter" and is indicative of the fact that it doesn't matter at which symbol positions the "SCAT" symbols are selected.)

(50) Other reels strips to those illustrated in FIG. 3 can be used, for example, reel strips where two or more WILD symbols are placed at consecutive reel strip positions of a reel strip. In other examples, the reel strips could have between 30 and 100 reel strip positions. The actual length of the reel strips depends on factors such as the number of WILD symbols (in general, the more WILDs there are, the longer the reel strip needs to be to maintain the target RTP), the number of trigger symbols on each reel, and volatility (in general, the higher the prize value is, the longer the reel strip needs to be to lower the hit rate to maintain the target RTP).

(51) FIG. 4 is a flow chart of a method **400** carried out by the processor **204** to select symbols from

reel strips. At step **410**, the processor **204** starts the process of selecting symbols with a counter (n) set at zero as symbols have not yet been selected from any reel strips. At step **420**, the processor **204** increments the counter. In the first iteration, the counter is set to 1 to reflect that symbols are to be selected from a first reel strip. At step **430** the processor obtains a randomly generated number from a true or pseudo random number generator, such as RNG **212**. At step **440** the processor maps the generated number to one of the reel positions of the nth reel strip. In the first iteration, this is the first reel strip. To map the generated number to one of the reel strip positions, the possible values that can be returned from the RNG **212** are divided into ranges and associated with specific ones of the reel positions in memory **208**. In one example, these ranges are stored as a look-up table. In one example, the ranges are each the same size so that each of the reel strip positions has the same chance of been selected. In other examples, the ranges may be arranged to weight the relative chances of selecting specific reel strip positions. The reel strips may be of different lengths.

(52) At step **450**, the processor **204** maps symbols of the nth reel strip to and nth column of symbol display positions based on the mapped reel strip position and a reference position. In an example, the reference position is the bottom position of the symbol positions of each column of symbol positions. In this example, the selected reel position (and hence the symbol at this position) is mapped to the bottom symbol position of the column. In an example, there are two other symbol positions in the column of symbol positions and hence symbols at two neighboring reel strip positions are also mapped to the symbol positions of the column. That is, in effect, selecting one reel strip position selects a portion of the reel strip having three reel strip positions for display. Referring to the example reel strips of FIG. 3, if the value returned by the RNG **212** is mapped to reel position **313**, then for the first reel strip **321**, “SCAT 3” symbol **343** is mapped to a bottom symbol position, “10” symbol **342** is mapped to a middle symbol position, and “J” symbol is mapped to a top symbol position. It will be appreciated that the same technique can be used to select a different number of symbols from each reel strip by using a different number of neighboring reel strip positions.

(53) At step **460**, the processor **204** determines whether symbols have been selected for all of the reel strips, and if not the processor reverts to step **420** and iterates through steps **430**, **440** and **450** until it is determined at step **460** that symbols have been selected from all n reel strips and mapped to all n columns of symbol positions after which the symbol selection process ends **470**. Different numbers of symbols may be mapped to different numbers of symbol positions.

(54) After the symbols of all reel strips have been mapped to symbol position, at step **525**, the processor **204** controls display **240** to display the selected symbols at the symbol positions.

(55) FIG. 5 is a flow chart of a method **500** of operating a gaming device **200** of an embodiment. At step **510**, the gaming device **200** receives the player's wager which is input as described above. In this example, the number of pay lines are fixed and the only option available to a player is to select a different bet amount (in effect a bet multiplier). At step **520**, the processor **204** selects symbols for display on display **240** from reel strips stored in the memory **208**.

(56) At step **530**, the processor **204** evaluates the selected symbols for winning combinations based on a pay table stored in memory **208**. In an example, the processor **204** checks each pay line activated by the player's wager to determine whether it has a winning combination of symbols (e.g. three, four or five of a symbol included in the pay table). In an example, the processor **204** evaluates each pay line from left to right—i.e. the winning combination must start in the left most column. WILD symbols substitute for all other symbols in this evaluation. The processor **204** makes an award for each winning combination based on any selected bet multiplier by adding an award to a win meter stored in memory **208**. In an example, there are 50 pay lines and each wager involves activating all pay lines—i.e. the number of pay lines are fixed.

(57) As described above, the reel strips comprise three trigger symbols (SCAT **1**, SCAT **2** and SCAT **3**). In an embodiment, the selection of a respective symbol results in a chance of triggering an associated free-game feature game (Ft **1**, Ft **2**, Ft **3**). Where more than one trigger symbol is

selected, in addition to there being a chance of triggering the respective feature game, there is a chance of triggering features that combine game play characteristics of the individual feature games which are combined to form composite features (Ft 1+2, Ft 1+3, Ft 2+3, Ft 1+2+3). Whether a single feature or composite feature is triggered depends on a weight table. An example of a weight table is set out in Table 1 below:

(58) TABLE-US-00001 TABLE 1 Ft1 Ft2 Ft3 Ft (1 + 2) Ft (1 + 3) Ft (2 + 3) Ft (1 + 2 + 3) None (sum) Scat 1 0.5 0 0 0 0 0 0.5 1 Scat 2 0 0.5 0 0 0 0 0.5 1 Scat 3 0 0 0.5 0 0 0 0.5 1 Scat 1&2 0.2 0.2 0 0.1 0 0 0 0.5 1 Scat 1&3 0.2 0 0.2 0 0.1 0 0 0.5 1 Scat 2&3 0 0.2 0.2 0 0 0.1 0 0.5 1 Scat 1to3 0.1 0.1 0.1 0.08 0.04 0.04 0.04 0.5 1

(59) In order to implement this functionality, at step 540, the processor 204 determines whether the selected symbols include one or more trigger symbols. In this respect, it will be appreciated step 540 can be initiated before or after the symbols are displayed. The processor 204 also determines the identity of each trigger symbol and uses the identity of the trigger symbol(s) to select a set of one or more trigger probabilities from the table at step 550. In this respect, referring to Table 1, in an example, where only a SCAT 1 is selected, processor 204 determines that a trigger probability of 0.5 applies to triggering the first feature game (Ft1), and hence there is a probability of 0.5 that no feature will trigger. In another example, where SCAT 1, SCAT 2, and SCAT 3 are selected, a trigger probability of 0.1 applies to triggering a first feature game, a trigger probability of 0.1 applies to triggering a second feature game, a trigger probability of 0.1 applies to triggering a third feature game, a trigger probability of 0.08 applies to a first composite feature game having characteristics of the first and second feature games, a trigger probability of 0.04 applies to a second composite feature game having characteristics of the first and third feature games, a trigger probability of 0.04 applies to a third composite feature game having characteristics of the second and third feature games, and a trigger probability of 0.04 applies to a fourth composite feature game having characteristics of the first, second and third feature games.

(60) Based on the assigned trigger probability or probabilities, the processor 204 assigns ranges of values returnable by RNG 212 to the respective feature games. The processor 204, then at step 560, determines a trigger outcome based on the trigger probability or probabilities by obtaining a value from RNG 212 and comparing the returned value to the assigned ranges. If the returned value corresponds to one of the assigned ranges, the trigger outcome is that the processor 204 awards the relevant feature game at step 570, and after controlling the display 240 to indicate that feature game is awarded conducts 580 the relevant feature game as will be described in further detail below. In the example, of Table 1, a possible trigger outcome for all combinations of trigger symbols is that no feature game is triggered.

(61) It will be appreciated that in another example, the weight table may associate ranges of values returnable from the RNG 212 with specific outcomes rather than specifying probabilities.

(62) Table 1 is only one example where $N=3$ is the number of trigger symbols and there are up to $2^{\text{circumflex over } (N-1)}=7$ triggerable features plus a probability of triggering no feature. In an alternative example, a feature game may trigger each time a trigger symbol lands, such that the processor 204, effectively only determines a trigger outcome that defines which of the $2^{\text{circumflex over } (N-1)}=7$ triggerable features will trigger, not whether a feature will trigger.

(63) In another example, where $N=2$ there may only be two trigger symbols and up to $2^{\text{circumflex over } (N-1)}=3$ triggerable features, with or without a probability of triggering no feature. In another example, there may be more than three trigger symbols. In an example, not all possible combinations of trigger symbols are mapped to a feature game. For example, where $N=4$, in one example, there are feature games associated with each individual trigger symbol and each combination of two trigger symbols but not with combinations of three or more trigger symbols.

(64) An example set of feature games and how their characteristics are combined to form composite features is set out below.

(65) Feature 1 (Reel Growth and Nudge WILDs—the “Prosperity Feature”)

(66) In this example, Feature 1 is triggerable based on an assigned trigger probability when SCAT 1 is a selected trigger symbol. When Feature 1 is triggered, 5 free games are awarded. During Feature 1 the array of symbol positions “grows” so that there are 6 symbol positions in each column. In each of the free games, 100 pay lines are played—i.e. will be evaluated by processor 204. As described below, at least during the free games, the reel strips that are employed include stacks of at least 6 WILD symbols. If a WILD appears in any position on reels 2, 3, 4, and/or 5 (that is in the relevant column of symbol position), the relevant reel(s) is nudged (moved to a new position) so that all symbols on that reel become WILD symbols. A nudge animation is played. The symbols are evaluated by the processor 204 after the reels have been nudged. As explained further below, a further feature game may be triggered during Feature 1.

(67) Feature 2 (Additional Games and Multipliers—the “Longevity Feature”)

(68) Feature 2 is triggerable based on an assigned trigger probability when SCAT 2 is a selected trigger symbol. When Feature 2 is triggered, 5 free games are awarded. During Feature 2, every SCAT 2 symbol that is selected awards 1 free game, 2 free games, or a bonus credit prize. These selections are made by the processor 204 from a weight table in memory 208 without replacement such that, for example, once all possible instances of awarding 2 free games have occurred (assuming this happens first), any future occurrences of a SCAT 2 symbol, will either result in the award of 1 free game or a bonus credit prize. A multiplier is applied to all line wins during Feature 2. In an example, the value of the multiplier is 3. This multiplier is displayed in the top right corner of the main screen. As explained further below, a further feature game may be triggered during Feature 2.

(69) Feature 3 (the “Jackpot Feature”)

(70) Feature 3 is triggerable based on an assigned trigger probability when SCAT 3 is a selected trigger symbol. When Feature 3 is triggered, 10 free games are awarded. SCAT 1, SCAT 2, and SCAT 3 symbols are replaced on the reel strips by “GOLD SCAT” symbols in this feature. A “GOLD SCAT” symbol is a “configurable symbol” that is determined dynamically by selecting from a number of possible “configuring symbols”—i.e. a set of symbols that can take the place of a “GOLD SCAT” symbol or be displayed at the reel strip position on the reel strip where the GOLD SCAT symbol is placed.

(71) Each GOLD SCAT appearing when configured with a configuring symbol reveals either a credit prize or a letter which is a component of at least one prize. In an example, the letters “M”, “I”, “N”, “A”, “J”, “O”, “R”, “G”, “N”, and “D” correspond to components of the “GRAND”, “MAJOR”, “MINOR”, and “MINI” prizes. In one example, shown in some of the figures described below, there are separate symbols for each of the prizes. In the illustrated example, different colors are used for each prize—e.g. there are three different colored “M” configuring symbols. As described further below, the configuring symbols are selected by a two-stage process of first selecting a weight table, and second selecting a configuring symbol in accordance with the selected weight table.

(72) Any credit prize appearing during the free games is instantly awarded.

(73) Progress toward the award of each awardable prize (such as progressive jackpots, bonus prizes or a mixture of progressive prizes and bonus prizes) is indicated by displaying the names: “GRAND”, “MAJOR”, “MINOR”, and “MINI” with letters yet to have been selected greyed-out and letters that have been selected in color.

(74) If a letter is selected from the reel strips, it is counted towards spelling one of the progressive names. When the name of the progressive is completely collected, the respective progressive is awarded.

(75) In an example, there are tables for each of the “GRAND”, “MAJOR”, “MINOR”, and “MINI” prizes. As described in further detail below, the tables are used “without replacement” and contain a set of undetermined, reference letters as well as credit prizes.

(76) For example, the “GRAND” table contains reference letters “GRAND_1”, “GRAND_2”,

“GRAND_3”, “GRAND_4”, and “GRAND_5”, each with a unique weight. At the start of Feature 3, these reference letters are randomly (even chance) assigned a letter corresponding to the progressive level by processor **204**. For example, “GRAND_1”, “GRAND_2”, “GRAND_3”, “GRAND_4”, and “GRAND 5” will be randomly assigned one of “G”, “R”, “A”, “N”, or “D” letters for the remainder of Feature 3.

(77) After any prize is awarded the progress indicated by the prize name is reset by the processor (here by greying all the letters out) and the prize can potentially be won again during the remainder of the feature. Weight tables are reset if all configurable symbols within the weight table have been used.

(78) A further feature cannot be triggered during this feature.

(79) Composite (or “Super”) Feature 1 Derived from Feature 1+Feature 2

(80) A number of game play characteristics of Feature 1 are incorporated into Super Feature 1, including that 5 free games are awarded, the number of symbols selected for each column of symbol positions grows to 6 symbol positions high and 100 lines are played. Further, if a WILD symbol appears in any position on reels **2, 3, 4**, and/or **5**, the reels are nudged so that all symbols on that reel become WILD symbols. A number of characteristics from Feature 2 are incorporated too. Specifically, every SCAT **2** that appears during the feature awards 1 free game, 2 free games, or a bonus credit prize as described above. Further, a multiplier is applied to all line wins during the feature. The value of the multiplier is 3. An additional feature game may be triggered from Super Feature 1.

(81) Composite (or “Super”) Feature 2 Derived from Feature 1+Feature 3

(82) When Super Feature 2 is awarded, 10 free games are awarded (from Feature 3). SCAT **1**, SCAT **2**, and SCAT **3** are replaced by GOLD SCAT during this feature (from Feature 3) and each column grows 6 symbol positions high and 100 lines are played (from Feature 1).

(83) As in Feature 1, if WILD appears in any position on reels **2, 3 4** and/or **5**, the reels are nudged so that all symbols on that reel become WILD. Further, line wins are multiplied by 3.

(84) As in Feature 3, each GOLD SCAT appearing has a configuring symbol which is either a credit prize or a letter “M”, “I”, “N”, “A”, “J”, “O”, “R”, “G”, “N”, and “D”, which is a component of a prize that can be awarded if all letters are collected in the manner described above.

(85) Composite (or “Super”) Feature 3 Derived from Feature 2+Feature 3

(86) In Super Feature 3 10 free games are awarded. As described in relation to Feature 3, SCAT **1**, SCAT **2**, and SCAT **3** are replaced by the configurable symbol GOLD SCAT and each GOLD SCAT appearing is configured by a configuring symbol which is either a credit prize or a letter M”, “I”, “N”, “A”, “J”, “O”, “R”, “G”, “N”, and “D”, that is a component of a prize that can be collected.

(87) As with Feature 2, line wins are multiplied by 3. A further feature cannot be triggered during this feature.

(88) Composite (or “Mega”) Feature 4 Derived from Feature 1, Feature 2 and Feature 3

(89) Ten (10) free games are awarded. The game play characteristics from Feature 1 are that each column grows 6 symbol positions high and 100 lines are played.

(90) The configurable GOLD SCAT symbol and prize component collection characteristics from Feature 3 are incorporated too. As in Feature 1, if WILD appears in any position on reels **2, 3, 4**, and/or **5**, the reels are nudged so that all symbols on that reel become WILD. Further, line wins are multiplied by 3. A further feature game cannot be triggered during the Mega Feature.

(91) FIGS. **6, 7**, and **8** are example screen displays during a process of a composite feature being triggered as a result of processor **204** carrying out steps **540** to **570** of FIG. **5**. In this example, Composite Feature 4, the “Mega” Feature game, is triggered.

(92) FIG. **6** shows an example screen display of the base game. Symbols are selected for twenty symbol positions arranged in five columns **611-615** and four rows **621-624**. Screen display has an indicator **601** to indicate that the player is playing 50 lines. In an upper part of the screen display,

current values are displayed for a GRAND progressive jackpot **631**, a MAJOR progressive jackpot **632**, a MINOR bonus prize **633** and a MINI bonus prize **634**.

(93) Bags **641**, **642**, **643** of coins correspond to a Prosperity Feature, Jackpot Feature, and Longevity Feature, respectively. The size of the bag is indicative of how many trigger symbols have appeared since the respective feature was last triggered.

(94) In one example, each of the bags **641**, **642**, **643** has five possible states as set out in Table 2.

(95) TABLE-US-00002
TABLE 2 State of bag BAG 641 BAG 642 BAG 643
1 0-4 0-4 0-4
2 5-9 5-9 5-9
3 10-14 10-14 10-14
4 15-24 15-24 15-24
5 25+ 25+ 25+

(96) In the screen display of FIG. 6, five trigger symbols **651**, **652**, **653**, **654**, **655** have landed. In an example, the trigger symbols are color coded to enable them to have a common appearance yet be associated with the respective feature games. In one example, SCAT 1 symbols **652**, **654** associated with the Prosperity Feature are green in color and the Prosperity Feature bag **641** is also green in color. SCAT 2 symbols **651**, **654** associated with the Longevity Feature are purple in color and the Longevity Feature bag **643** is also purple in color. SCAT 3 symbol **653** associated with the Jackpot Feature is red in color and the Jackpot Feature bag **642** is also red in color. As all three trigger symbols have landed, the processor **204** uses the set of probabilities associated with the occurrence of all three feature, and in this case evaluation of the trigger probabilities results in the Mega Feature being triggered.

(97) As each trigger symbol is displayed, an animation indicates to the player that they have a chance to trigger a feature game by showing the relevant trigger symbol as being added to the bag associated with the trigger symbol. FIG. 7 illustrates an example, of a SCAT 1 symbol **752** landing in the second column and a pair of images of the SCAT 1 symbol **752A**, **752B** moving towards the Prosperity Feature bag **641**.

(98) In FIG. 8, a message **810** is displayed with the text “MEGA FEATURE WON! 10 FREE GAMES. Grow reels and nudge WILDs! <GOLD COIN> (the “GOLD SCAT” symbol) awards additional free games or credit prizes! Collect and win Jackpots! PRESS START FEATURE.”

(99) FIG. 9 shows an initial screen of the Mega Feature. As the reels have “grown” or expanded, there are now six symbol positions in each column **611-615** of symbol positions arranged in 6 rows **921-926**. In the upper part of the display, a current status is displayed for each of the GRAND prize **931**, MAJOR prize **932**, MINOR prize **933**, and MINI prize **934**. In FIG. 9, each of the current statuses is an initial status where all of the letters of a respective prize status are greyed out to indicate to the player that none of the component symbols of the respective prize (here the letters of the name of the prize) has been collected. Background **704** has been changed from a base game background to a gold background to indicate that the player is playing the Mega Feature. A first indicator **701** indicates to the player that 100 pay lines are now active. A second indicator **702**, indicates that a “×3” multiplier is active, and a third indicator **703** indicates that the Mega Feature is active. In other examples, the component symbols could be representative of a non-cash prize, for example, four parts of a car that if collected award a car as a prize.

(100) Ten configurable symbols **961-970** are shown in an unconfigured state to indicate to the player that configurable symbols will be part of play of the Mega Feature.

(101) While in the above examples each Super or Mega Feature incorporates game play characteristics of other feature(s), it should be appreciated that a Super or Mega feature need not include game play characteristics of other feature(s). A Super or Mega feature may be a completely different feature that includes no game play characteristics of other feature(s).

(102) Referring to FIG. 10, there is shown a method **1000** of conducting the Mega Feature. At step **1002** the Mega Feature is triggered. This is as a result of the processor **204** carrying out step **560**. The gameplay characteristics of the Mega Feature are outlined above. It will be appreciated that an understanding of how the other features, or composite features, are conducted can, in part, be gained by reference to FIG. 10, in particular, by considering those parts of the flowchart of FIG. 10 which are relevant to the specific feature or composite feature.

(103) At step **1004**, the processor **204** changes the display **240** to display the initial screen for the Mega Feature (in an example, to the screen display shown in FIG. **9**).

(104) At step **1006**, the processor **204** sets a counter in order to keeping track of the free games to an initial value. In this example, the processor **204**, sets the counter to ten free games.

(105) At step **1008**, the processor begins conduct of the first free game by decreasing the counter by one.

(106) At step **1010**, the processor selects symbols from the Mega Feature reel strips. As described above, the Mega Feature symbol reel strips are modified relative to the base game reel strips shown in FIG. **3**. In one example, in order to implement the modification, the processor retrieves a specific set of reel strips for the Mega Feature, which are stored separately in memory **208** to the base game reel strips shown in FIG. **3**. In this respect, the reel strips for the “Mega Feature” can also have additional differences to the base reel strips.

(107) A set of Mega Feature reel strips **1100** are shown in FIG. **11** to indicate an example of differences between the Mega Feature reel strips **1100** and the base game reel strips. As with the reel strips shown in FIG. **3**, the length of the reel strips and the symbols thereon are illustrative only. In particular, the reel strips for the Mega Feature can be of a different length to the base game reel strips. As illustrated in FIG. **11**, there are five reel strips **1121-1125** and fifteen reel strip positions, **1101-1115**. Instead of the individual scatter symbols associated with particular feature games, there are “GOLD SCAT” symbols on each of the reel strips. As will become apparent from the example screen displays described below, the GOLD SCAT symbols initially bear no indicia and hence can be thought as configurable symbols. These configurable symbols are initially displayed in unconfigured state when selected and then configured by selecting a configuring symbol (in some examples, the processor **204** may begin selecting the configuring symbols once the processor **204** has selected the configurable GOLD SCAT symbols and before they have been displayed. The reel strips also include stacks of WILD symbols as exemplified by stack **1155** of six WILD symbols. In an example, the reel strips are longer than the fifteen reel strip positions shown and there is at least one stack of WILD symbols on each of reels **1122-1125**.

(108) The process of selecting symbols from the reel strips of FIG. **11** conducted at step **1010** is the same as that outlined in relation to FIG. **4** above, except that six contiguous symbols will be selected from each reel strip for display in the six symbol positions of each column as outlined in FIG. **9**. The processor **204** then controls display **240** to display the selected symbols at the display positions.

(109) At step **1020**, the processor determines whether any of the selected symbols are configurable symbols. Examples of the configurable symbols shown in an unconfigured state are shown in FIG. **12** where symbols **1201**, **1202**, **1203** and **1204** are unconfigured configurable symbols. In this example, the configurable symbols are referred to as GOLD SCAT symbols because they are originally displayed as gold coins and they are evaluated irrespective of whether they are on a pay line.

(110) As shown in FIG. **12**, the player can win one or more of four prizes. Indeed, as explained in further detail below, the player can also win a particular prize more than once. Current statuses are shown for each prize. In FIG. **12**, as with FIG. **9**, these are shown in an initial state where no progress has been made towards winning the jackpot prize. When there are one or more configurable symbols, the processor **204** selects a weighted table from memory **208** to apply to this instance of configuring a configurable symbol. In this example, there are four weighted tables corresponding to each of the prizes. Each of the weighted tables has each of the letter of the respective prize (e.g. the letters “G”, “R”, “A”, “N”, and “D” for the GRAND prize) and other symbols that relate to the award of further free games or credit prize awards. The selection of a weighted table is weighted by the processor **204** using a further weighted table at step **1022** to determine which weighted table is selected in order to control the relative probability of one of the particular prize tables being used. In an example, the weighted table for selecting the prize letter

weighted table, is such that selection of the lower prize letter tables is more likely than the higher prize letter tables. In order to select a prize letter weighted table, the processor obtains a number from RNG **212** and compares it to a range of values corresponding to the relative probabilities of selecting the particular weighted tables. The generated random number is matched by the processor **204** to a range and from this the table is selected. The processor **204** then conducts, at step **1024**, a similar process in order to select a configuring symbol from a weighted table for that prize. The process conducted by processor **204** at step **1024** similarly involves assigning ranges of values to respective ones of the configuring symbols by the letters of a prize, any credit prizes and any free game prizes, and obtaining a number from the RNG **212** to compare to these ranges in order to select the configuring symbols. A distinction is that once a symbol has been selected, it is “removed” from the table by the processor so that it cannot be selected again, for example by setting a flag that the symbol has been selected. This ensures that, for example, in the case of MAJOR prize **932**, that the letter “J” can only be selected once. As a result, each time a configurable symbol is configured with a letter, this will result in one of the prize statuses being updated.

(111) At step **1026**, the processor determines whether all configurable symbols selected in this free game have been configured and if not, the processor **204** reverts to step **1032**.

(112) Upon it being determined by the processor **204** at step **1026** that all the configurable symbols have been configured, the processor **204** proceeds to step **1028** and determines whether any of the symbols correspond to the award of one or more extra free games. That is if a configurable symbol has been configured with a free game symbol, the processor updates the counter at step **1030** to reflect the additional free game(s).

(113) At step **1032**, the processor **204** determines whether the configurable symbols have been configured with any credit prizes and, if there are, makes an award of the credit prizes by adding them to a win meter in memory **208** at step **1034**.

(114) At step **1036**, the processor **204** determines whether any of the configurable symbols includes prize component symbols (i.e. the letters of a prize). If they do, at step **1038**, the processor **204** updates the status of the relevant prize. In order to distinguish between the letters of the different prizes, each of the letters are in a different color so that when a letter is shared by the prizes, such as is the case with the letter M, the player can readily appreciate which prize will be updated. In one example, the GRAND prize letters are red, the MAJOR prize letters are green, the MINOR prize letters are blue and the MINI prize letters are yellow.

(115) At step **1040**, it is determined whether any prizes have been completed by the processor **204** determining whether the defined set of prize component symbols (here, the letters of a particular prize) have been collected. If a prize has been completed, at step **1042**, the processor **204** makes an award by adding the award amount to the win meter and resets the corresponding one of the statuses. At this stage, the processor **204** also resets the weighted table associated with the completed prize so that all symbols can be selected from the weighted table. In this way, it is possible for the player to collect the defined set of prize component symbols of a particular prize again, after it has been awarded, thereby providing an additional chance of winning the prize. Further, different ones of the four prizes can be completed within the free game series, or even during the same free game of the free game series.

(116) FIGS. **12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21**, and **22** illustrate the process of steps **1020-1042**, in more detail by giving an example of the graphical representations accompanying the process conducted by processor **204**.

(117) At step **1050**, the processor **204** determines whether any WILD symbols have been selected for display. At step **1055**, if one or more columns of symbols include a WILD symbol, the symbols are nudged so that an entire stack of six WILD symbols are displayed at the symbol positions. An example of this process is shown in FIGS. **23** and **24** where initially three WILD symbols **2301, 2302, 2303** are displayed in the fourth column **614** of symbol positions. As shown in FIG. **24**, the

position of the fourth reel strip has been adjusted by moving it so that there are now six WILD symbols **2301-2306** in the fourth column **614**.

(118) In one example, any stack of WILD symbols is sufficiently spaced from a configurable symbol so that they cannot appear at the same time in order to avoid a configurable symbol being nudged off the reels. In an alternative example, a configurable symbol may be nudged off a reel. In a further alternative example, any configurable symbols that appear are configured with configuring symbols and the prize status is updated by the processor **204** prior to conducting the process of nudging the symbol.

(119) As indicated above, in the example shown in FIG. **12** there is a first free game in which configurable symbols **1201-1204** have been selected. Referring to FIG. **13**, a first of these configurable symbols has been configured with the “R” prize component symbol to produce configured symbol **1201A**. In this example, the configured “R” symbol belongs to the GRAND prize and is colored red.

(120) In FIG. **14**, a second of the configurable symbols **1202A** has been configured with a yellow “M” prize component symbol corresponding to the MINI prize **934**. In FIG. **14**, there is also an animation **1021B** of the “R” prize component symbol moving towards the GRAND prize.

(121) In FIG. **15**, an updated GRAND prize status **931A** is displayed with the letter “R” **1501** within the word “GRAND” changing to indicate that a portion of the prize has been collected. In this way, progress toward completing the entirety of the prize is displayed to the player.

(122) In FIG. **16**, a further configurable symbol **1203A** has been configured with the green letter “A” corresponding to the MAJOR prize **932**. FIG. **16** also shows an animation of the yellow letter “M” **1202B** moving towards the MINI prize **934**.

(123) FIG. **17** shows that the fourth configurable symbol has been configured to include a green letter “R” corresponding to the MAJOR prize. FIG. **17** also shows an animation of the green letter “A” **1203B** towards the MAJOR prize **932**.

(124) FIG. **18** is a screen display at a later stage of the game. At this stage of the game, the GRAND prize status **931C** is that letters “G”, “R”, “A”, and “N” have been collected, representing four prize component symbols of the set of possible five prize component symbols required to complete the GRAND prize. Similarly, the letters “A”, “J”, “O”, and “R” of the MAJOR prize have been collected as indicated by MAJOR prize status **932A**, representing four prize component symbols of the five prize component symbols required to be collected in order to be awarded the MAJOR prize. MINOR prize status **933A** shows that the letters “I” and “O” have been collected. Finally, MINI prize status **934B** indicates that the letters “M”, “N”, and “I” have been collected and that one additional “I” prize component symbol is required in order to complete the MINI prize. As also shown in FIG. **18**, a further configurable symbol has been selected and has been configured with the yellow letter “I” prize component symbol corresponding to the MINI prize.

(125) As shown in FIG. **19**, MINI prize status **934C** is updated by animating yellow letter “I” symbol **1902** within MINI prize status **934C**.

(126) FIG. **20** shows that following completion of the award, a completed MINI prize **934D** is shown and a prize award message **2010** is displayed to indicate to the player that they are a “mini bonus winner” and that the prize has a value of “\$100”.

(127) Referring to FIG. **21**, after the prize is awarded, the MINI prize **934** is reset to its initial status, while GRAND prize status **931C**, MAJOR prize status **932A**, and MINOR prize status **933A** remain unchanged. For example, in a subsequent free game, a configurable symbol is selected and configured with the orange letter “D” prize component symbol corresponding to the GRAND prize, the GRAND prize will be awarded, in addition to the earlier award of the MINI prize within the free game series. As another example, if in the same subsequent free game, a further configurable symbol is selected and configured with the green letter “M” prize component symbol corresponding to the MAJOR prize, the MAJOR prize is further awarded during the same free game.

(128) FIG. 22 shows a subsequent free game where a further yellow letter “I” prize component symbol **2201** has been used to configure a selected configurable symbol resulting in the update of the MINI prize status **934E** to indicate that one of the “I” letters has been selected.

(129) In this respect, it will be apparent from a comparison of FIG. 22 and FIG. 18 that the specific configurable symbols are also associated with specific positions within the prize where a letter is repeated. That is, when a letter “I” is selected in the MINI prize, it will be displayed at a specific position in this example.

(130) Referring again to FIG. 10, subsequent to the completion of the Jackpot Feature sub-process of the Mega Feature, at step **1060**, the processor **204** evaluates symbols on win lines (in this example, 100 lines) using a pay table stored in memory **208** and by applying a three times multiplier. Any awards for winning combinations are made to a win meter in memory **208**.

(131) At step **1065**, the processor **204** determines whether the counter has reached zero and if not, reverts to step **1008** to conduct a further free game. Once the counter reaches zero, the processor **204** proceeds to step **1070** of ending the Mega Feature game. In some examples, at the end of the Mega Feature game, the processor **204** may control the display to display the total amount won during the Mega Feature.

(132) FIG. 25 illustrates an example of when the Jackpot Feature is conducted by itself to show some of the differences as compared to the Mega Feature. As shown in FIG. 25, there are twenty display positions arranged in five columns **611-615** and four rows **621-624**. Indicator **2501** includes the text “Jackpot Feature” to indicate to the player that they are playing the jackpot feature. FIG. 25 illustrates that the GRAND, MINOR, and MINI prizes all have their initial statuses whereas the letter “A” has been collected towards the MAJOR prize status **932B**. Two further configured configurable symbols **2511** and **2512** have been selected and configured during the 4th of the 10 free games as, respectively, letter “M” and letter “R”. An animation of the letter “R” symbol **2511A** is shown as moving towards the MAJOR prize. A further configurable symbol **2513** is yet to be configured. From FIG. 25, the skilled person will appreciate that a major difference during conduct of the standalone Jackpot Feature is that there are fewer symbol positions at which configurable symbols can be selected.

(133) FIG. 26 is a flowchart of a method **2600** for retriggering one or more feature games of an embodiment of the disclosure. In the example set of feature games described above, a feature game can be retriggered from each of the feature and composite feature games except triggering from the jackpot feature and the composite feature games that incorporate the jackpot feature. This is because when the jackpot feature is conducted (or game play characteristics of the Jackpot Feature are incorporated into a composite feature) there are no trigger symbols in the feature game. In this specific example composite feature 1 is the only composite feature that does not include the jackpot feature. An advantage of the method of FIG. 26 is that it enables a further composite feature to be triggered from within a feature game.

(134) At step **2605**, the processor **204** conducts a free game series which, in the example above, can be the five free games of the Prosperity Feature (feature 1), the five free games of the longevity feature (feature 2) or the five free games of the first composite feature which combines the play characteristics of features 1 and 2.

(135) At step **2610**, the processor sets a counter to an initial value of free games. In this example five free games.

(136) At step **2615**, the processor decreases the counter by one. At step **2620**, the processor selects symbols from reel strip.

(137) FIG. 27 shows one example set of reel strips **2700**, which can be used in the Prosperity Feature. In this example, there are five-reel strips **2721-2725** and fifteen-reel strip positions are illustrated **2701-2715**. The reel strips include three different trigger symbols for example SCAT 3 symbol **2741**, SCAT 1 symbol **2742** and SCAT 2 symbol **2743**. The symbols of the reel strips **2721-2725** also include stacks of symbols such as stack **2701**.

(138) The process of selecting symbols conducted at step **2615** is generally as outlined in relation to FIG. **4** above.

(139) At step **2625**, the processor **204** determines whether the selected symbols include one or more trigger symbols. If the selected symbols include one or more trigger symbols, processor proceeds to step **2630** and evaluates a trigger probability associated with each trigger symbol. Assuming no features have been triggered, the processor **204** separately determines, for each appearing trigger symbol, whether to trigger the feature game which the trigger symbol is associated. To do so, the processor **204** obtains values from the RNG **212** and compares the obtained values to a range corresponding to the probability. In this example, once a feature has been triggered, any further occurrences of the trigger symbol are not evaluated.

(140) At step **2635**, the processor **204** determines whether a feature is triggered on the basis of the evaluation and if it is, at step **2636**, the processor sets the feature as triggered. The processor **204** then proceeds to step **2637** of evaluating the symbols.

(141) In the examples set of feature games described above, certain of the feature games, such as composite feature 1 and feature 2, every SCAT **2** symbol that appears during the feature game awards one free game, two free games, or bonus credit prize. Accordingly, the step **2637** of evaluating the symbols includes adding any bonus prize from the credit symbols and updating the counter to add any additional free game. The step of evaluating the symbols **2637** also comprises that determining whether any pay line has a winning combination specified in a pay table stored in memory **208**. Where the feature game is the composite feature 1 or feature 2, a multiplier is applied to any line win. All wins are added by processor **204** to the win meter in memory **208**.

(142) At step **2640**, the processor **204** determines whether the counter has reached zero and if not, the processor **204** reverts to carrying out step **2615**. Once the counter reaches zero, the processor proceeds to step **2645** and determines whether there are one or more triggers. If there are not, the processor **204** ends the game at step **2655**. If there are one or more triggers, the processor **204** starts a feature based on the triggered features **2650** that have been collected during the series of free games which will be a composite feature if two or more features are conducted.

(143) FIGS. **28, 29, 30, 31, 32, 33** and **34** illustrate an example of this process in relation to a number of screen displays. In particular, the figures show how two triggers can be collected during the “Prosperity Feature” which lead to conducting a composite feature game that incorporates both the Prosperity and Longevity play characteristics. This is the feature game described as composite featured game 1 above.

(144) As shown in FIG. **28** when the Prosperity Feature game is triggered, a message **2805** is displayed with the text “Prosperity Feature won! Five free games. Grow reels and nudge WILDs! Press start feature” is displayed. As shown in FIG. **29**, the processor **204** then changes the display screen to incorporate a layout similar to that shown in FIG. **9** where there are five columns **611-615** and six rows **921-926**. Indicator **2905** indicates that the Prosperity Feature is in progress.

(145) As shown in FIG. **29**, a SCAT **3** symbol **2915** corresponding to the Longevity Feature has landed and is being animated **2915A** as moving towards bag **3143**. Referring now to FIG. **30**, in this instance, the appearance of the trigger symbol has caused a trigger probability to be evaluated and the feature to be collected. As a result, bag **3143** is updated to provide an updated representation **3143A** of the bag with the underlying text “trigger collected” to indicate that the trigger for the Prosperity Feature has been collected.

(146) FIG. **31** shows a further trigger symbol **3111** (here a SCAT **1** symbol) has landed on the second reel **612** and is being animated **3111A** as moving towards Prosperity bag **3141**.

(147) Again, in this example, the processor **204** has determined that this instance of appearance of the trigger symbol has resulted in the trigger being collected and as shown in FIG. **32** the representation of the bag **3141A** is updated to show that the trigger for the Prosperity Feature has been collected.

(148) Accordingly, at the end of the free games both the Prosperity trigger and the Longevity

trigger have been collected and the processor **204** determines on that basis that it should conduct a composite feature game 1. Here, the Prosperity Longevity Super Feature (Super Feature 1 described above) the processor **204** controls the display **240** to display the message “Prosperity Longevity Super Feature won! Five free games. Grow reels and nudge WILDs! SCAT 2 symbol awards additional free games or credit prizes! Press start feature”.

(149) FIG. **34** shows an example of a screen layout for the Prosperity Longevity Super Feature. In this example, there are five columns **611-615** of symbol positions and here six rows **921-926**. Indicator **3405** indicates that the player is playing the Prosperity Longevity Super Feature game. Indicator **3407** indicates that a three times multiplier applies and indicator **3409** indicates that one hundred lines will be evaluated.

(150) Innovations described herein can be implemented in a server computers **102** and/or gaming device **104A, 104B, 104C, 104X, 200** described with reference to FIGS. **1** and **2**. Thus, a server computer **102** or gaming device **104A, 104B, 104C, 104X, 200** is an example of an electronic gaming device as described with reference to FIGS. **1** and **2**.

(151) For example, for the electronic gaming device, a game controller such as the game controller **202** described with reference to FIG. **2** can perform operations to use a trigger symbol graphic, symbol collection graphic, bag graphic, symbol movement graphic, or symbol transformation graphic. In some example implementations, the game controller **202** can control display of a trigger symbol graphic, symbol collection graphic, bag graphic, symbol movement graphic, or symbol transformation graphic. In particular, the game controller **202** can, if the supplemental feature has been triggered in a feature game, control display of the trigger symbol graphic, symbol collection graphic, bag graphic, symbol movement graphic, or symbol transformation graphic, as reset, and otherwise control display of the trigger symbol graphic, symbol collection graphic, bag graphic, symbol movement graphic, or symbol transformation graphic with a current state advanced to a next state value. In some cases, the game controller **202** may selectively trigger the supplemental feature and adjust a trigger symbol graphic, symbol collection graphic, bag graphic, symbol movement graphic, or symbol transformation graphic. In particular, the game controller **202** can, if the supplemental feature is triggered, reset the trigger symbol graphic, symbol collection graphic, bag graphic, symbol movement graphic, or symbol transformation graphic, and otherwise advance the current state of the trigger symbol graphic, symbol collection graphic, bag graphic, symbol movement graphic, or symbol transformation graphic to a next state value.

(152) A typical electronic gaming device is a specially-configured computer system, and not merely a general-purpose computer. For example, one difference between a typical electronic gaming device and common processor-based computer system is that the electronic gaming device is designed to be a state-based system. In a state-based system, the system stores and maintains its current state in non-volatile memory, which can be implemented using battery-backed RAM, flash memory, a solid-state drive, or other persistent memory. Different functions of a game (e.g., bet, play, result, points in the graphical presentation, etc.) may be defined as a state. When a game moves from one state to another, data regarding the game state is stored in a custom non-volatile memory subsystem. In some cases, the gaming device does not advance from a current state to a subsequent state until information that allows the current state to be reconstructed is stored. In the event of a power failure or other malfunction, the gaming device will return to its current state when the power is restored by recovering state information from non-volatile memory. The restored state may include metering information and graphical information that was displayed on the gaming device in the state prior to the malfunction. For instance, if a player was shown an award for a game of chance and, before the award could be provided to the player, the power failed, the gaming device, upon the restoration of power, would return to the state where the award is indicated.

(153) More generally, the gaming device records, in non-volatile memory, the values of game parameters assigned during play, such as variables determined by an RNG or internal counters. (A

game parameter, in general, can be one or more variables whose values govern play at the gaming device and depend on a random selection process.) The value of a game parameter can be recorded periodically, in response to some event such as user input, or whenever the value of the game parameter changes. This way, the gaming device can recover its state in case of a power failure or “tilt” event, allowing the gaming device to reconstruct events that have taken place before the power failure or “tilt” event. This requirement affects the software and hardware design on a gaming device. Game history information regarding previous games played, such as an amount wagered, the outcome of the game and so forth, may also be stored in a non-volatile memory device.

(154) In the context of the innovations described herein, for example, a game controller **202** can save information about the current state of a trigger symbol graphic, symbol collection graphic, bag graphic, symbol movement graphic, or symbol transformation graphic in non-volatile memory at various stages. After the trigger symbol graphic is reset to an initial state value, or after the state of the trigger symbol graphic advances to a higher state value, the game controller **202** can save information in non-volatile memory that indicates the state value. The non-volatile memory can also store other state information, such as a current bet amount, bet level, an amount of credits remaining, and/or a win amount for a base reel game, bonus reel game, and/or other supplemental feature. More generally, non-volatile memory can store state information such as positions of the respective reels, in addition to storing information that indicates the configuration of reel strips of the reels. After finishing a base reel game or supplemental feature, the game controller **202** can store information in non-volatile memory that indicates an outcome (e.g., award amount) or status.

(155) Approaches described herein address the technical problem of how to manage interaction between a trigger symbol graphic, symbol collection graphic, bag graphic, symbol movement graphic, or symbol transformation graphic, and a triggering event for selectively triggering a feature.

(156) In terms of technical effects, innovative features of a triggering event with a trigger symbol graphic, symbol collection graphic, bag graphic, symbol movement graphic, or symbol transformation graphic, represent improvements in the technical area of electronic gaming software and provide new technology, in that they improve usability of electronic gaming devices by enhancing the user experience for players and rewarding a player for extended play time on the electronic gaming devices. In some example implementations, the progression of a trigger symbol graphic, symbol collection graphic, bag graphic, symbol movement graphic, or symbol transformation graphic for the triggering event is visible to players. In particular, the progression of a trigger symbol graphic, symbol collection graphic, bag graphic, symbol movement graphic, or symbol transformation graphic for the triggering event may provide a build up to triggering of a feature, which may occur as a reward to players for extended play on an electronic gaming device. These embodiments are thus not merely new game rules or new display patterns.

(157) In at least the state-adaptive variations, true-persistence implementations, and skipped-enhancement variations described herein, using a boost stage with a metamorphic graphical element, such as the trigger symbol graphic, symbol collection graphic, bag graphic, symbol movement graphic, or symbol transformation graphic, offers new ways to achieve a desired game volatility (e.g., increase game volatility) while maintaining a designated level of RTP for a game. Furthermore, by managing weighted tables and/or other aspects of random number generation events for a boost stage with a trigger symbol graphic, symbol collection graphic, bag graphic, symbol movement graphic, or symbol transformation graphic, game play can be kept fair and consistent with regulations while also enabling variation of game volatility for a designated level of RTP for a game.

(158) Thus, some aspects of the disclosure provide a method of awarding a feature prize on a gaming device having a display operable to display a first prize and a second prize, the first prize including a plurality of first prize components, and the second prize including a plurality of second

prize components, and a game controller having a processor, a random number generator operable to generate one or more random numbers, and a memory storing a plurality of base symbols, a plurality of trigger symbols, and a plurality of prize component symbols, and instructions, which, when executed, cause the game controller to initiate a feature game. The display device displays a plurality of symbols selected based on one or more random numbers in a plurality of symbol positions in a game area on the display. The processor determines if the plurality of symbols selected include one or more of the plurality of trigger symbols, in response to determining that the plurality of symbols selected include one or more of the plurality of trigger symbols, controls the display device to display the plurality of trigger symbols being configured into a corresponding number of prize component symbols, animates a filling of a plurality of respective prize components of the first prize and the second prize with the corresponding number of prize component symbols; and presents one of the first prize and the second prize when the plurality of respective prize components of the first prize and the second prize have been completely collected.

(159) In one embodiment, the instructions, when executed, cause the at least one processor to animate one of the plurality of trigger symbols to move from one of the plurality of symbol positions into a corresponding prize component of one of the first prize and the second prize.

(160) In one embodiment, the instructions, when executed, cause the at least one processor to determine if a trigger condition has been met, and in response to determining that the trigger condition has been met, increase the plurality of symbol positions in the game area.

(161) In one embodiment, the memory further stores a plurality of weighted prize tables. The instructions, when executed, cause the at least one processor to select a first weighted prize table of the plurality of weighted prize tables, and to apply the first weight prize table to configure the plurality of trigger symbols.

(162) In one embodiment, the first weighted prize table corresponds to a lower prize, and a second weighted prize table corresponds a higher prize. The instructions, when executed, cause the at least one processor to select the first weighted prize table more likely than the second weighted prize table.

(163) In one embodiment, the first prize is associated with the first weighted prize table, and the first weighted prize table further stores a plurality of probabilities corresponding to a plurality of first prize component symbols. The instructions, when executed, cause the at least one processor to randomly select one of the plurality of first prize component symbols based on the plurality of probabilities to configure one of the plurality of trigger symbols.

(164) In one embodiment, each of the plurality of first prize components comprises a first letter of a plurality of letters, and each of the prize component symbols comprises a second letter of the plurality of letters.

(165) In one embodiment, the instructions, when executed, cause the at least one processor to determine if the first letter matches the second letter before completing the plurality of respective prize components.

(166) In one embodiment, the instructions, when executed, cause the at least one processor to remove the second letter for selection from the plurality of prize component symbols.

(167) In one embodiment, the instructions, when executed, cause the at least one processor to determine if the plurality of symbols selected include a free game symbol, and in response to determining that the plurality of symbols selected include the free game symbol, initiate a free game.

(168) In one embodiment, the instructions, when executed, cause the at least one processor to reset the one of the first prize and the second prize to be available for award again when the one of the first prize and the second prize has been awarded.

(169) In one embodiment, the instructions, when executed, cause the at least one processor to reset an associated weight table for the one of the first prize and the second prize that has been awarded.

(170) In one embodiment, the instructions, when executed, cause the at least one processor to

determine if the plurality of symbols selected include a predetermined symbol, and, in response to determining that the plurality of symbols selected include the predetermined symbol in a column of symbol positions, animate a nudging of each of the column of symbol positions to display the predetermined symbol.

(171) In one embodiment, the instructions, when executed, cause the at least one processor to conduct the nudging when the one of the first prize and the second prize has been awarded.

(172) In one embodiment, the instructions, when executed, cause the at least one processor to animate a stack of predetermined symbols from the predetermined symbol by a predetermined number of display positions.

(173) In one embodiment, the instructions, when executed, cause the at least one processor to associate each of the corresponding number of prize component symbols with a unique position in the plurality of first prize components.

(174) In one embodiment, the instructions, when executed, cause the at least one processor to grey out the plurality of first prize components and the plurality of second prize components when initiating a feature game.

(175) In one embodiment the instructions, when executed, cause the at least one processor to conduct the feature game as a series of free games.

(176) In one embodiment, the feature game comprises a series of free games, the method further comprises conducting the series of free games.

(177) In one embodiment, the first prize is associated with a first color, the second prize is associated with a second color, each of the corresponding number of prize component symbols is associated with one of the first color and the second color.

(178) In one embodiment, the instructions, when executed, cause the at least one processor to collect each of the plurality of respective prize components at a time.

(179) It will be appreciated that the above provides but one example of how a composite feature can be retriggered within a series of free games.

(180) While the disclosure has been described with respect to the figures, it will be appreciated that many modifications and changes may be made by those skilled in the art without departing from the spirit of the invention. Any variation and derivation from the above description and figures are included in the scope of the present invention as defined by the claims.

Claims

1. An electronic gaming system comprising: a gaming device operable to display one or more symbols at a plurality of display positions; and at least one server coupled to the gaming device, the at least one server comprising at least one processor and a memory storing i) a symbol set including a plurality of configurable symbols, ii) a plurality of prize component weighted tables, each of the plurality of prize component weighted tables comprising a plurality of configuring symbols and corresponding to each of a plurality of prizes, and iii) instructions, which, when executed, cause the at least one processor to at least: control the gaming device to display a plurality of symbols selected based on at least one random number generated by a random number generator at the plurality of display positions, control the gaming device to display, in response to the plurality of symbols displayed including a first configurable symbol of the configurable symbols, the first configurable symbol being configured into a first prize component with a first configuring symbol selected from a first prize component weighted table selected to control a relative probability of a first prize among the plurality of prizes, control the gaming device to animate a first portion of the first prize being transformed with the first prize component, and control the gaming device to animate a payout in response to a predetermined number of portions of the first prize having been transformed.

2. The electronic gaming system of claim 1, wherein the instructions, when executed, further cause

- the at least one processor to remove the first configuring symbol from the first prize component weighted table selected after the first configuring symbol has been selected.
3. The electronic gaming system of claim 2, wherein the instructions, when executed, further cause the at least one processor to restore the plurality of configuring symbols in the first prize component weighted table after the payout.
4. The electronic gaming system of claim 1, wherein each of the plurality of prizes has a respective predetermined number of portions to be transformed.
5. The electronic gaming system of claim 1, wherein the instructions, when executed, further cause the at least one processor to animate the first prize component being moved from one of the display positions toward the first portion of the first prize spaced apart from the display positions.
6. The electronic gaming system of claim 1, wherein the plurality of prize component weighted tables comprises a second prize component weighted table associated with a second prize, the second prize being greater than the first prize, and wherein the instructions, when executed, further cause the at least one processor to more likely select the first prize component weighted table than the second prize component weighted table.
7. A method of displaying a plurality of prizes on an electronic gaming system having a gaming device coupled to at least one server that comprises at least one processor and a memory storing a symbol set including a plurality of configurable symbols and a plurality of prize component weighted tables comprising a plurality of prize component symbols and corresponding to each of the plurality of prizes, the method comprising: animating at the gaming device a plurality of symbols selected randomly based on at least one random number generated by a random number generator; in response to the plurality of symbols including a first configurable symbol, animating on the gaming device the first configurable symbol being configured into a first prize component with a first prize component symbol selected from a first prize component weighted table selected to control a relative probability of a first prize among the plurality of prizes; animating at the gaming device a first portion of the first prize being filled with the first prize component; and animating at the gaming device a payout of the first prize in response to a predetermined number of portions of the first prize having been transformed.
8. The method of claim 7, further comprising removing the first prize component symbol from the first prize component weighted table selected after the first configuring symbol has been selected.
9. The method of claim 8, further comprising restoring the plurality of prize component symbols in the first prize component weighted table after the payout.
10. The method of claim 7, wherein each of the plurality of prizes has a respective predetermined number of portions to be transformed.
11. The method of claim 7, further comprising animating the first prize component being moved toward the first portion of the first prize.
12. The method of claim 7, wherein the plurality of prize component weighted tables comprise a second prize component weighted table associated with a second prize, the second prize being greater than the first prize, and the relative probability of selecting the first prize component weighted table is higher than the relative probability of selecting the second prize component weighted table.
13. The electronic gaming system of claim 1, wherein the first prize further comprises at least one of a progressive prize, a bonus prize, and a mixture of the progressive prize and the bonus prize.
14. The method of claim 7, wherein the first prize further comprises at least one of a progressive prize, a bonus prize, and a mixture of the progressive prize and the bonus prize.
15. A non-transitory computer-readable medium comprising a symbol set including a plurality of configurable symbols, ii) a plurality of prize component weighted tables, each of the plurality of prize component weighted tables comprising a plurality of configuring symbols and corresponding to each of a plurality of prizes, and a plurality of instructions for conducting a game on a gaming device coupled to a server, the plurality of instructions, which, when executed, cause a processor to

perform the steps of: controlling the gaming device to display a plurality of symbols selected based on at least one random number generated by a random number generator at the plurality of display positions; controlling the gaming device to display, in response to the plurality of symbols displayed include including a first configurable symbol of the configurable symbols, the first configurable symbol being configured into a first prize component with a first configuring symbol selected from a first prize component weighted table selected to control a relative probability of a first prize among the plurality of prizes; controlling the gaming device to animate a first portion of the first prize being transformed with the first prize component, and controlling the gaming device to animate a payout in response to a predetermined number of portions of the first prize having been transformed.

16. The non-transitory computer-readable medium of claim 15, wherein the instructions, when executed, further cause the processor to perform the step of removing the first configuring symbol from the first prize component weighted table selected after the first configuring symbol has been selected.

17. The non-transitory computer-readable medium of claim 15, wherein the instructions, when executed, further cause the processor to perform the step of restoring the plurality of configuring symbols in the first prize component weighted table after the payout.

18. The non-transitory computer-readable medium of claim 15, wherein each of the plurality of prizes has a respective predetermined number of portions to be transformed.

19. The non-transitory computer-readable medium of claim 15, wherein the instructions, when executed, further cause the processor to perform the step of animating the first prize component being moved from one of the display positions toward the first portion of the first prize spaced apart from the display positions.

20. The non-transitory computer-readable medium of claim 15, wherein the plurality of prize component weighted tables comprises a second prize component weighted table associated with a second prize, the second prize being greater than the first prize, and wherein the instructions, when executed, further cause the processor to perform the step of selecting the first prize component weighted table more likely than the second prize component weighted table.
